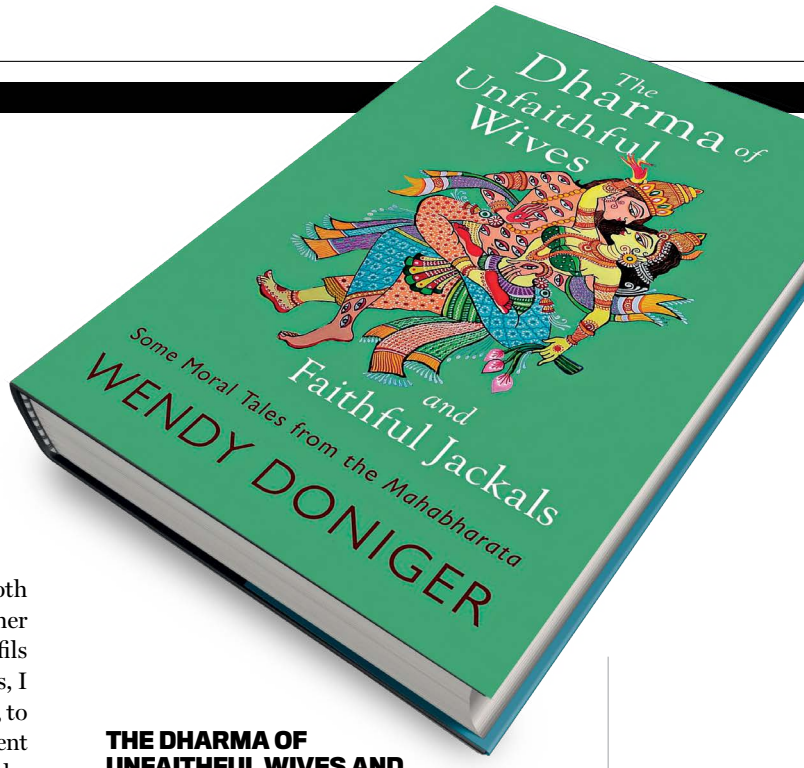


THE DHARMA OF UNFAITHFUL WIVES AND FAITHFUL JACKALS
Moral Tales from the Mahabharata
by Wendy Doniger
SPEAKING TIGER
₹**499; 224** pages

A new book from Wendy Doniger always creates a stir—both friends and foes are eager to see what she has to say. Neither group is ever disappointed, each finds something that fulfils their expectations. Having been her student in the 1980s, I fall firmly in the first group and I am delighted, yet again, to read her lucid, bright translations that are marvellously fluent in English and yet, retain something of the lilt and pace of the Sanskrit original. If you have any doubt about this rare skill of Doniger's, you have only to read 'How the Procrastinator Saved Gautama from Killing His Wife'—you will experience the pleasure of Sanskrit puns and sarcasm even as you laugh out loud for what it sounds like in English.

As always with Doniger, this is primarily a book of stories. Drawn from classical Sanskrit texts (here, the Mahabharata), this collection includes stories we know, stories we don't know, characters we know whose actions are mainly familiar and sometimes are surprisingly against what we know, and a host of named and unnamed magical creatures and supernatural beings. For me, that is sufficient. But Doniger also provides us, in her brief commentaries, with new perspectives and insights and a veritable symphony of resonances and contrapuntal melodies that we can enjoy.

In this book, Doniger returns, after 50 years of wide-ranging scholarship, to the themes and ideas of her early work—women, animals, Shiva, the origins of 'evil' in Hin-

BOOKS

Ancient Hymn, Modern Verse

Vikram Seth's *translation of Tulsidas's Hanuman Chalisa captures the incantatory quality of the original*

Literary translation is famously difficult and translating poetry particularly so. More challenges arise when the poem in question is a 40-verse (*chalisa*) hymn in Avadhi, the language of Ayodhya, to the godly Hanuman, a poem that is loved and recited daily by millions of Hindus. Poet-novelist Vikram Seth calls his latest publication, *The Hanuman Chalisa*, a labour of love published several years after its completion in which he renders the incantatory quality of the original Avadhi into English poetry, the first ever such attempt.

Through his translation, **SETH** restores Hanuman to the original conception of Valmiki and Tulsidas

The poet's preface states his intention to acquaint the English-speaking world with this magical, joyful work that encapsulates a whole culture in fewer than 90 lines. With this portable little book, Seth joins legions of poets with his own telling of a mini-Ramayana.

Without Hanuman, there would be no Ramayana. Over 2,000 years ago, this miracle-working monkey and the remover of obstacles, was created in the poetic imagination of Adikavi Valmiki in Sanskrit. Sixteen hundred years later, Tulsidas composed the Hanuman Chalisa as an offshoot to his magnum opus Ramacharitamanas in Avadhi verse in which this monkey devotee of Rama born with earrings and supernatural powers was transformed into a divine being. Today, a contemporary poet has successfully captured the es-